

Comparative Essay 2: Decolonization Choices

Due: Monday, November 30 at 11:59 PM

Value: 175 points

Format: 1,500-1,800 word comparative essay

Purpose

Compare how leaders and movements navigated constrained choices during decolonization without treating independence as a single event.

Your task

- Choose two cases from India/Pakistan, Algeria, Ghana, Indonesia, Kenya, or Vietnam between 1945 and 1975.
- Answer: How did the relationship among mass mobilization, violence, international pressure, and inherited state institutions shape the options available after formal independence?
- Use at least four primary sources, with attention to both elite strategy and lived experience.
- Distinguish choices actors made from structural constraints and hindsight assumptions.
- Evaluate one important consequence visible within ten years of independence and explain why it does or does not support your thesis.

Recommended workflow

- Case-selection note due in class November 9.
- Evidence matrix workshop November 18.
- Optional outline feedback by November 23.

Submit

- 1,500-1,800 word essay PDF with Chicago footnotes and bibliography.

Grading criteria

Criterion	Pts	Full-credit evidence
Comparative thesis	30	Makes a specific, arguable comparison that answers the prompt.
Historical evidence	45	Uses accurate, specific evidence from both cases and at least four primary sources.
Analysis	45	Explains similarity, difference, causation, and significance rather than listing facts.
Organization	25	Paragraphs develop the comparison directly with clear transitions.
Context and qualification	15	Situates both cases and addresses a limitation or counterexample.
Style and citation	15	Clear prose and complete Chicago-style citations and bibliography.

Submission standards

Upload a readable PDF unless the handout specifies another format. Include your name, course code, and assignment title. Cite borrowed ideas and retain the editable source file. The learning portal timestamp is the official submission time.